

LET'S GET IT out of the way... this game is hard! Even in 'Easy' mode, you're bound to lose to the computer team a few thousand times before you get a fluke victory—if at all! If anything, there's a little too much reality here when batting, and Sachin Tendulkar would struggle to reach double figures!

Graphics: Average

Let's start with the graphics, as all gamers would want to: two words, "nothing special!" Sure, fans of EA's *Cricket* series will now commission mercenaries to fetch them my head on a platter, but the truth is the truth! Look at it from my point of view, I've just finished playing *Half-Life 2* for the 9,826,283,745th time, and then I pop this game in and roll on the floor laughing uncontrollably at the pixellated look of the players!

Interface: Good

Next comes the menu interface: simple, easy to use, and with a decent amount of tweaking allowed in the settings. So far so good.

I'm impatient, so I decide to start a quick game just to see what all the fuss is about. Ahh! A screen that shows me the controls. Huh? Where did it go? What was that second button for? Yes, the keyboard controller map is shown before the start of each game, but only for about 0.0023485872534 seconds. So I had to read the manual, just to see which button did what. Any game that makes me read a manual isn't very user-friendly in my humble opinion.

Controls: Good

Oh well, on with the game. It's Australia vs Bangladesh, and I

am Australia (obviously!). Gilchrist walks in with Hayden, the stadium is beautiful, and packed to the brim with screaming fans. Gilchrist takes his stance, some Bangladeshi bowler runs up, I keep [Shift] pressed (this is the "Six Hit" button) and press [S] + [Down Arrow] + [Left Arrow]. The ball goes sailing over the long on boundary and into the second tier of fans amidst much cheering. "I love this game," I yell!

Five minutes later, Australia are all out for 9, and those three extra runs came from leg byes or no balls! Every time I play a shot, it goes straight to a fielder. Every time I try a "Six Hit", I get caught!

AI: Ridiculous

I can never seem to find the gaps—well actually I do, but these fielders make Jonty Rhodes look like Lord Nelson running a marathon!

Yes, to say the fielding is a little too good is an understatement! Every single player can run faster than the wind, has the throwing arm of Hercules, and can break the world long jump record AND take a catch—all at the same time!

Practise: Good

I realise I have jumped straight into the fire and decide I need a little practise. I head off for the nets. Bowling isn't really that hard, so I choose to practise my batting.

I learn that it's almost impossible to time a ball to perfection, and that you should never try a sweep shot to a bouncer! After an hour, I figure out how to time the ball. I think I'm ready!

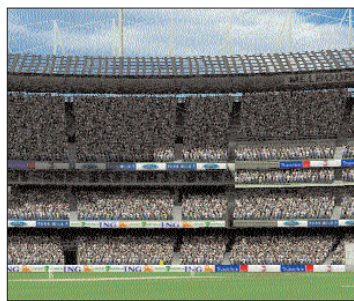
Next I do what most Indians would do: choose to be India, and play a match against Pakistan. I should have opted to be Pakistan!



And you thought games were easy to play...



L to R: Tendulkar, Ganguly, Yuvraj, and Shoaib. Only Shoaib looks believable



Stadiums look good in the day, and it's always a sold out affair



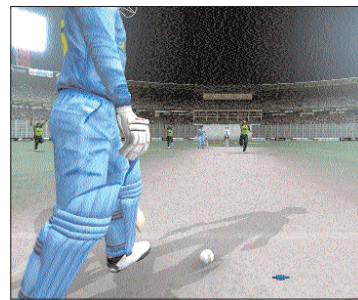
This Indian fielder ran 30 yards and took a diving catch—yeah right!



All the umpires have paunches. At least there's consistency



Even under the lights, you feel like you're really watching a match



There's even a pretty decent stump vision camera angle